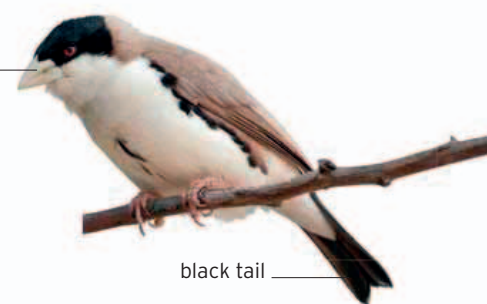


Black-capped social weaver

Pseudonigrita cabanisi

distinctive
white beak



black tail

Its name says a lot about this small, neat, handsome bird. The black cap, red eye, and pale beak give the black-capped social weaver a unique look. It shares the nest-building habit of all weavers, although the nests that this social weaver builds have a rough, unfinished appearance as compared to some weavers' more precise constructions. Like other weavers, this is a gregarious bird, living in flocks, nomadic when not breeding, and nesting in colonies that are a few to 60 pairs strong. The need for social stimulation seems to be strong among them. Perching birds often squeeze together shoulder to shoulder and occasionally even preen each other.

Restricted range

The black-capped social weaver is a very localized bird found only in a small part of East Africa, very nearly restricted to Kenya and Tanzania, where it inhabits low-lying dry thorn bush plains. In this limited range, it is common in suitable habitats. Flocks of birds feed on

the ground, foraging for seeds and a few grasshoppers; however, they frequently dash up to perch on treetops if disturbed. They should be a familiar bird to many safari-goers, but are often overlooked in parks and reserves where more glamorous big game claim most of the attention.

Expert builders

Breeding males create an insignificant, buzzy chattering from nesting trees, often flapping their wings; however, courtship is generally undistinguished. Nests often hang from tips of long, pendulous branches in a spreading acacia. A pair adds material all year round, using nests as roosts when not breeding. A new nest is built up above a slender twig in an arch and extended into a tubelike structure, with an entrance at the bottom. Eventually, the weight pulls the twig downward and the upper end of the tube is closed off. Up to four eggs are laid, but little is known about the chicks.

Large nests may contain more than 9,000 grass stems

► AT HOME

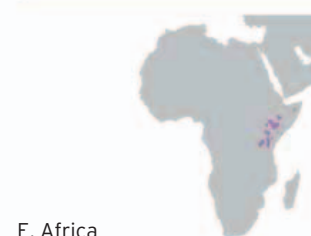
Black-capped social weavers use prickly grass stems to make an unlined, conical nest. When used for roosting it has two entrances; one is sealed off for breeding.

◄ NESTING TREE

Often, the largest tree in a wide area forms the basis for a breeding colony, holding up to 60 nests.



- ↔ 5 in (13 cm)
- ⚖ 5/8–7/8 oz (18–24 g)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🌾 Seeds
- 🏠



E. Africa